

Liberia(/country/lbr)

Liberia Humanitarian Situation Report No.75

Situation Report

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NOTE

These reports – whose aim to focus on broad issues and themes affecting the humanitarian community in Liberia as well as give regional situation updates – are now being issued biweekly. In the interim weeks, the Humanitarian Activity Report is issued. It provides an update on the sectoral activities of UN Agencies and International and National NGOs in Liberia.

The following issues are covered in this report:

1. Bridging programmes
2. Humanitarian Assistance in Southwest Liberia
3. Humanitarian Database Project

1. BRIDGING PROGRAMMES

Early indicators show that bridging projects have successfully aided the reintegration of ex-combatants into civilian life. But the lack of clearly-defined exit strategies for the transition to full-scale reintegration programmes threaten peace and stability. If a gap is created between the two programmes, ex-combatants might return to old command structures or to crime in order to survive.

Since November 1996, UNDP-UNOPS, the EU and UNDHA-HACO have together created more than 25,000 temporary jobs through bridging projects designed to support the peace process by giving demobilised fighters an alternative to living by the gun, assisting in their reintegration into civilian society and helping communities rebuild infrastructure such as roads, drainage systems, schools and hospitals. The EU has since November 1996 funded 128 projects, which were implemented through the Liberian National Disarmament and Demobilisation Committee and engaged approximately 7,500 ex-fighters and civilians. UNDP has since December 1996 launched, through its implementing arm UNOPS, 148 projects consisting primarily of road repair and drainage work in seven counties, which have created more than 10,000 temporary jobs. Lastly, since March, HACO has funded 44 projects worth USD 2.2 million that have created 8,352 temporary jobs. Implemented primarily through national NGOs, these projects have ranged from small-scale, quick-impact agricultural and fishing activities to public works projects. But as the name implies, these projects were meant to be temporary, short-term activities whose purpose was to create a conducive environment for reconciliation and provide immediate services pending the start-up of full-scale reintegration programmes.

Overall, the programmes appear to be quite successful in achieving the above-mentioned goals. In many communities, tension between ex-combatants and civilians seem to have lessened as a result of bridging programmes that brought the two groups together and problems with the ex-combatants themselves, such as an unwillingness to work and aggressive behavior, seem to be improving. They have also helped weaken command structures by creating alternatives for demobilised fighters.

The main task facing programmers now is the development of clearly-defined exit strategies. As bridging programmes phase out – UNOPS has exhausted its funding, the EU is beginning to convert its bridging programmes to, mainly agricultural, community development projects (CDPs), and HACO's bridging funds will be terminated – programmers are scrambling to come up with options for the future in the absence of a reintegration programme. Should a gap exist between the two programmes, meaning that the bridging programmes end with no alternatives in place, ex-combatants may return to their old command

structures or crime. Thus, a smooth transition to longer-term reintegration projects is crucial to the continued success and maintenance of peace and stability.

Hence, there is a need to ensure that bridging projects, as intended, form a basis for the direction and substance of long-term reintegration programmes. Additionally, the dynamics encountered in these projects reflect to a certain degree the difficulties Liberian society is faced with at the end of a seven-year civil war and which will continue to provide challenges to the humanitarian community. Based on a nine-day assessment of ten UNDHA-HACO projects in Bong, Lofa and Nimba counties and informal interviews with UNOPS and EU representatives, the following conclusions can be drawn:

1) The bridging projects seem to have been successful in minimizing if not eliminating many of the tensions between civilians and ex-combatants in many communities. The act of physically rebuilding community infrastructures through hard labor seems to fit in with Liberian ideas of repentance and has helped communities acknowledge ex-combatants' willingness to reform. The EU also reports great success with using sport (primarily football matches) as a way to break down barriers between ex-combatants and civilians. Both UNOPS and the EU reported anecdotal evidence, gathered mainly through community members, of reduced tension and crime rates, although neither has been quantified. It should be noted that any number of complementary factors, such as increased ECOMOG presence, could also explain any reduction in crime. Despite these impressions, instances exist where ex-combatants are still unwelcome. This is particularly evident in areas where ex-combatants are living in communities they do not consider home. In all cases, communities seem more willing to accept ex-combatants who are originally from the area.

Although many of the fighters demonstrate a genuine willingness to work, some have shown a lack of enthusiasm and a discouraging sense of entitlement. All three agencies have seen an improvement in ex-combatants willingness to work since the beginning of their programmes. Many ex-combatants, they say, seem to realize the benefits, take pride in their work, and apply themselves accordingly. Additionally, the EU reports that many ex-combatants are simply tired of fighting and ready to commit to a civilian life. However, seeing their friends use the money earned in the programmes to buy new clothes or in some cases start small businesses, some ex-combatants seem to regard the programmes as an opportunity for easy money. Under an agreed-upon policy between all partners, ex-combatants and other war-affected persons engaged in civil reconstruction works earn USD 1.00 a day with USD 0.25 for lunch, which is slightly above the average wage in the country. Another reason for their lack of commitment is that many fighters have not returned to their home areas, leaving them reluctant to contribute fully to a community that often remains alien to them. Additionally, the majority come to the work programmes with false or unrealistic expectations in regards to forthcoming assistance and, finding they have to work for their money, are less than enthusiastic.

Many still exhibit aggressive behavior. Again, all three agencies have seen an improvement in this area: the longer an ex-combatant stays in the programme, the more socially acceptable behavior they exhibit. However, some ex-combatants, particularly those in the front-line areas such as Gblo Dialla, Nimba County, which recently acted as the front-line between the defunct NPFL and LPC factions, remain more aggressive than others residing in areas that have traditionally been further away from the front-line. This makes the task of supervising and dealing with ex-combatants difficult. Disciplining them by expelling them from the work team is also problematic as implementors don't want to push them into a life of crime, but nor do they want to encourage anti-social behavior.

In instances where project supervisors coincidentally happened to be counselors, there appears to be a great degree of success in bringing ex-combatants and civilians together. In an EU programme in Ganta, project officers who are also trained counselors facilitate group meetings and are available for informal one-on-one counseling sessions. Holding the project up as an example, the EU says the presence of a counselor greatly enhanced the programme. UNOPS, which is embarking on a six-week healing and reconciliation pilot project in support of CRTs, and HACO officials, agree that future programmes should include counseling components.

Command structures seem to have been weakened by bridging projects, but not broken. For instance, ex-commanders in Lofa County refuse to allow their demobilised subordinates to leave them. However, after some of the former commanders left the area following the arrest of ULIMO-K leader Al Hadji Kromah and the deployment of ECOMOG, some of the young men subsequently joined bridging programmes. Without that alternative, the fighters may have turned to crime or moved to stay near

their commander. But, while bridging projects may combine with other factors such as ECOMOG's presence to weaken the command structure, they certainly are not sufficient enough to disintegrate factional command structures and, being short-term in nature, they will not guarantee long-term viability to ex-combatants. In the worst case scenario, former combatants might return to old command structures or to crime once bridging programmes end. It is for this reason, that the clear and timely long-term reintegration projects, which take into account the lessons learned during the bridging phase, must move forward as quickly as possible.

2. SOUTHWEST LIBERIA (GRAND CAPE MOUNT, BOMI, LOWER LOFA)

Security conditions in the region remain fair. Former combatants have been observed mainly in and around areas of ready income through the extraction of diamonds and rubber. However the organisation of former combatants under Graceland International in Bomi county, headed by former NPFL and ULIMO-J Generals, has raised concerns. The former combatants have made it known that they have not benefited from the promises extended during demobilisation particularly in regard to the coupons for education, agricultural kits and civil reconstruction work. Former combatants have also congregated in the Guthrie Rubber Plantation Programmes targeting these concerns suffer from the same constraints affecting humanitarian operations - notably limited funding, resources, transport and accessibility and lack of implementing partners. Former combatants in Lower Lofa and Upper Grand Cape Mount are less concerned about lack of access to benefits most probably due to their domination of the diamond trade. The 2,500 RUF combatants and followers in Bopolu have begun dispersing into surrounding communities. An estimated 300 are known to have moved to the Wuesua area for the diamond mining. ICRC continues to provide assistance as well as LWF-WS which has included the RUF in seeds and tools distributions. Anecdotal reports have indicated that some of the RUF are anxious to return to Sierra Leone to join their fellow combatants, however movement to the west is constrained by the rising waters of the Lofa River. An unevaluated point is the possible role to be played by the Sierra Leonean ECOMOG at Lofa Bridge which sits on the main east west corridor.

Coverage in all sectors remains sparse. Key constraints have been the delays in donor funding for INGOs, poor road conditions and the relatively recent, late February, opening of the area to unfettered humanitarian operations. Significant movements of population have been occurring throughout the region with displaced populations returning to communities in Lower Lofa, northern and western Grand Cape Mount and Bomi in general, while there have no movements of new refugees from Sierra Leone. However, the region has suffered extensive destruction of infrastructure affecting general accessibility, health, WATSAN, education and resettlement. Main access routes through the area are deteriorating with the onset of the rains making assistance more problematic. An assessment of accessibility on the unmarked logging road from Lofa bridge to Vahun in Lofa was able to travel 118 Km north before the route became impassable. UNOPS, WVI, SCF-UK, CONCERN, LWF-WS and the EC are all working on road and bridge projects throughout the area.

Distribution of seeds and tools is proceeding slowly resulting in increased observation of many overgrown farms that had been previously cleared. There is concern that incomplete coverage of agricultural assistance may require planning for Food for Work and other targeted feeding in these areas to make up for the shortfall in food availability in the coming months. Destruction and contamination of most wells and pumps will require a significant effort in the WATSAN sector. OXFAM is addressing needs in south eastern Grand Cape Count and is the only WATSAN project in the region. Given last years experience of cholera outbreaks in the area and the increased population in the region, the health sector should prepare to respond to a more widespread incidence of cholera. Health services remain limited. Populations in Lower Lofa are served by clinics only in Bopolu and Wuesua. In Bomi County, PMU Interlife work with the elderly, the Liberian National Red Cross (LNRC) clinic in Tubmanburg, the WVI clinic at Government Farm as well as the out-patient department services of the Tubmanburg Hospital form the extent of services. In Grand Cape Mount County, WVI has a clinic in Madina, MDM mobile clinics are providing health care in Robertsport, Tahn and Jenewonde, while OXFAM's efforts to provide fixed health services in the western half of the county are stalled pending approval of funding.

Education activities remain limited due to extensive destruction of school facilities. However, ActionAid has completed an assessment of education needs in the region that also looked at adult education requirements and will make the results available shortly.

3. HUMANITARIAN DATABASE PROJECT

UNDHA-HACO database aids coordination by mapping, graphing and analyzing the impact of key humanitarian, social, economic and, to a limited extent, political indicators on humanitarian activities in Liberia. For now, online access is limited to HACO due to lack of technology in Liberia. But plans underway to create a Monrovia intranet and full-scale Internet access.

To aid in coordination efforts, UNDHA-HACO has recently developed a Relational Database Management System (RDBMS) that - in addition to processing information from 22,000 interviews with ex-fighters during the disarmament exercise -- is being used to map, graph and analyze the impact of key humanitarian, social, economic and, to a limited extent, political indicators on humanitarian activities in Liberia. Although the results are currently being shared with the humanitarian community, at present the DHA-designed database can be accessed at only one computer station located in HACO's main Monrovia office. But plans are underway, in collaboration with Volunteers in Technical Assistance, to allow all humanitarian agencies in Liberia to access the system through a Monrovia intranet. Full Internet access is planned to be available by August 1997 dependent on successful negotiations between a Monrovia Internet service provider and Liberia Telecom.

To date, the database has been used to:

Develop profiles of former fighter groups in Liberia from more than 22,000 ex-fighter interview records. This information is being used by UN Agencies and NGOs to design programmes with reintegration elements tailored specifically for former combatants. For example, UNDP used the database to identify individual senior-ranking faction officers who, based on their pre-war educational level and current age, qualified for an academic scholarship programme. Additionally, the HACO team has compared the daily demobilisation rates with other indicators such as fluctuations in the US dollar- Liberian dollar exchange rate and security trends and events. This type of analysis has enhanced our understanding of the effect of the peace process on the Liberian economy, perceptions of stability and other social sectors.

Establish a comprehensive digital listing and description by county and sector of more than 748 humanitarian activities taking place throughout the country. A crucial tool for coordination and planning efforts, this list helps prevent overlapping and duplication of projects and reveals gaps in coverage by documenting the activities of each organisation in a centralized database. Furthermore, humanitarian activities can be listed by geographical location, sector or agency as the need arises and can be further broken down by the cost or the number of beneficiaries as fits agency planning requirements.

Analyze approximately 2,600 separate estimates of populations and population movements around Liberia. Due to shifting populations and limited access too much of the country until recently, population estimates crucial to programming have been difficult to come by in Liberia. Now, in collaboration with UNDP, FAO, UNOPS, ACF, WVI, LIURD, SCF-UK, CRS, UNOMIL, HACO has produced a comparative listing of various populations from county to village levels. These figures are periodically reviewed and reissued to reflect population movements and achieve the highest degree of accuracy possible.

Produce detailed digital mapping of agency interventions by sector for co-ordination purposes. So far, HACO has mapped all activities of the health sector and is in the process of mapping the activities in the other sectors. These maps can then be directly compared to geographical representations of population concentrations, security incidents and demobilisation activity.

Routinely track commodity prices, exchange rates, security-related events, humanitarian assessments, distributions of assistance-relief items, and staff turnover. By monitoring these indicators, HACO is quickly building an accurate and dynamic picture of a variety of activities in Liberia, which will help agencies in planning.

This report is available on the internet through RELIEFWEB: <http://www.reliefweb.int>

Mr. Tesema Negash
UN Humanitarian Coordinator - Monrovia
Tel.: (231) 226 041-042
Fax: (874) 175 46 27 (sat.)

Inter-Agency Support Branch (IASB) Geneva
Mr. David Bassiouni - Chief

Mr. Chris Kaye

Tel.: (41 22) 788.6385

Fax: (41 22) 788.6389

Registry E-Mail: Rosemary.Addo-Yirenkyiatdha.unicc.org

Complex Emergencies Division (CED) New York

Mr. Peter Due

Tel.: (1 212) 963.1731

Fax: (1 212) 963.3630

E-Mail: dueatun.org

Press to contact (DHA-Geneva)

Ms. Madeleine Moulin-Acevedo

Tel.: (41 22) 917.2856

Fax: (41 22) 917.0023

Telex: 414242 DHA CH

E-Mail: Moulin-Acevedoatdha.unicc.org

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